
HOMELESSNESS IS A HOUSING PROBLEM

Research evidence on housing affordability, homelessness, and substance use | October 2026

The central distinction

Individual crises such as job loss, illness, family conflict, and addiction can increase someone's risk of losing housing. But research comparing communities finds that rents and housing availability are powerful explanations for why homelessness is much more widespread in some places than others.

What the research shows

No single study can prove that affordable housing explains every individual episode of homelessness. Together, however, the following studies provide strong evidence that housing-market conditions are central to the scale of homelessness, while behavioral-health conditions are important, overlapping vulnerabilities.

01 Homelessness Is a Housing Problem (2022)

Gregg Colburn and Clayton Page Aldern analyzed differences in homelessness rates across U.S. regions. Their central finding: housing markets, particularly high rents and scarce housing, are stronger explanations of regional differences in homelessness than commonly cited factors such as substance use and mental illness.

Source: University of California Press, Gregg Colburn and Clayton Page Aldern (2022)

<https://www.ucpress.edu/books/homelessness-is-a-housing-problem/paper>

How to cite it accurately: This is a comparison across places, not a claim that addiction never contributes to an individual's homelessness.

02 U.S. Government Accountability Office (2020)

In an analysis of homelessness and rental-market data, the GAO estimated that a \$100 increase in median monthly rent was associated with approximately a 9% increase in the homelessness rate, holding other measured factors constant.

Source: GAO-20-433, Homelessness: Better HUD Oversight of Data Collection Could Improve Estimates of Homeless Population (2020)

<https://www.gao.gov/products/gao-20-433>

How to cite it accurately: An estimated statistical association, not a universal causal rule for every city.

03 California Statewide Study (2023)

UCSF surveyed approximately 3,200 adults experiencing homelessness in California and conducted in-depth interviews. About 90% had lost their last housing in California and about 75% in the same county where surveyed. The report describes the central role of low incomes, housing instability, and affordability constraints.

Source: UCSF Benioff Homelessness and Housing Initiative (2023)

<https://homelessness.ucsf.edu/resources/reports/toward-new-understanding-california-statewide-study-people-experiencing>

How to cite it accurately: Residency findings rebut broad “outsider” narratives; they do not directly measure the causal effect of housing costs.

04 Behavioral Health and Homelessness (2025)

UCSF reported that 35% of adults in its California study had used drugs regularly and that, among those reporting regular drug use, 42% said that regular use began after their first experience of homelessness. The sequence matters: substance use does not always precede homelessness.

Source: UCSF Benioff Homelessness and Housing Initiative, behavioral-health analysis (2025)

<https://homelessness.ucsf.edu/resources/reports/behavioral-health-and-homelessness>

How to cite it accurately: Timing alone does not prove homelessness caused drug use; the relationship can run in both directions.

05 Butte County Point-in-Time Survey (2025)

Butte County respondents identified financial or employment problems more often than alcohol or substance use as contributing circumstances. The survey reported roughly 31% selecting financial/employment issues, 26% family crisis, and 17% alcohol/substance use, based on the total PIT population.

Source: Butte Countywide Homeless Continuum of Care, 2025 PIT Executive Summary

https://www.buttehomelesscoc.com/uploads/1/1/7/5/117500423/2025_pit_executive_summary.pdf

How to cite it accurately: Multiple responses were allowed; the 17% reflects a reported contributing factor, not the prevalence of addiction.

06 HUD Family Options Study

A randomized study of 2,282 families experiencing homelessness found that offering long-term housing subsidies substantially reduced subsequent homelessness and housing instability compared with other interventions. This provides unusually strong evidence that direct access to stable housing can change outcomes.

Source: U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development, Family Options Study

https://www.huduser.gov/portal/family_options_study.html

How to cite it accurately: The results concern families with children in the study, not every person experiencing homelessness.

What these findings do ... and do not ... establish

- Supported: High rents and scarce available housing are major structural drivers of homelessness across communities.
- Supported: Addiction and mental-health conditions can contribute to homelessness, but they do not explain all cases or the large differences between places.
- Not supported: Claiming that every instance of homelessness is caused solely by housing costs, or that substance use never matters.
- Important: Emergency shelter, transitional housing, treatment, supportive housing, and permanent housing can all serve different needs. None requires criminalizing homelessness.

A concise public statement

“Homelessness is a housing problem. Addiction and mental illness are real health concerns, but research shows that housing costs and availability explain much of why homelessness is concentrated in particular communities. We need housing people can afford, alongside voluntary services and different pathways to stability.”

Prepared as a research handout. All statistics should be quoted with their study populations, dates, and limitations; original reports should be consulted for publication-quality sourcing.